

on their batting. It might not be as brazenly explosive as Australia's or India's, but it has served the side well of late. New Zealand scored at 8.73 an over in the PowerPlay in 2025, just short of its trans-Tasman rival and home favourite India.

A minor tweak at the top of the order could further sharpen its attack. Finn Allen has played just five games in this cycle but has an average of 36 to accompany a strike rate of 211. He is a more compelling option to partner Tim Seifert than Devon Conway, who hits at 124 and is yet to calibrate his game to the demands of modern T20.

Daryl Mitchell, Glenn Phillips and Mark Chapman form the middle order and have enough wares to build on momentum if given a platform. All-rounders Michael Bracewell and Santner can chip in too, but New Zealand will turn towards them more for their spin bowling in the dry subcontinent conditions.

An injury ruled Adam Milne out of the tournament, but New Zealand's pace unit looks insulated from such tremors. Since the last World Cup, Jacob Duffy has emerged as a linchpin in the pace battery, and only one bowler has taken more wickets than his tally of 44. He also boasts an enviable economy rate of 6.72. Kyle Jamieson, Lockie Ferguson and Matt Henry complete a well-rounded bowling unit.

Searching for answers

South Africa's fortunes have seen a downturn in the shortest format since its runner-up finish at the last World Cup. Only West Indies and Ireland have a worse win-loss ratio than the Proteas' 0.562 among Full-Member teams.

The void left by the international retirements of Heinrich Klaasen and Quinton de Kock has been evident.



Peaking at the right time: Dewald Brevis's recent SA20 form, highlighted by a 75 not out in Qualifier 1 and a 101 in the final, could be South Africa's biggest batting weapon at the T20 World Cup. AP

South Africa's run rate in the first six overs through this World Cup cycle has been a middling 7.30, a sharp drop from 9.47 in the previous cycle. Across the 20 overs, it has dipped from nearly nine per over to 8.12.

The return of de Kock should

mend this to an extent, but the team still needs the middle order to shoulder more burden.

This predicament could set the stage for Devald Brevis' coming of age. After striking at 172 and averaging 31 since July 2024, the

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